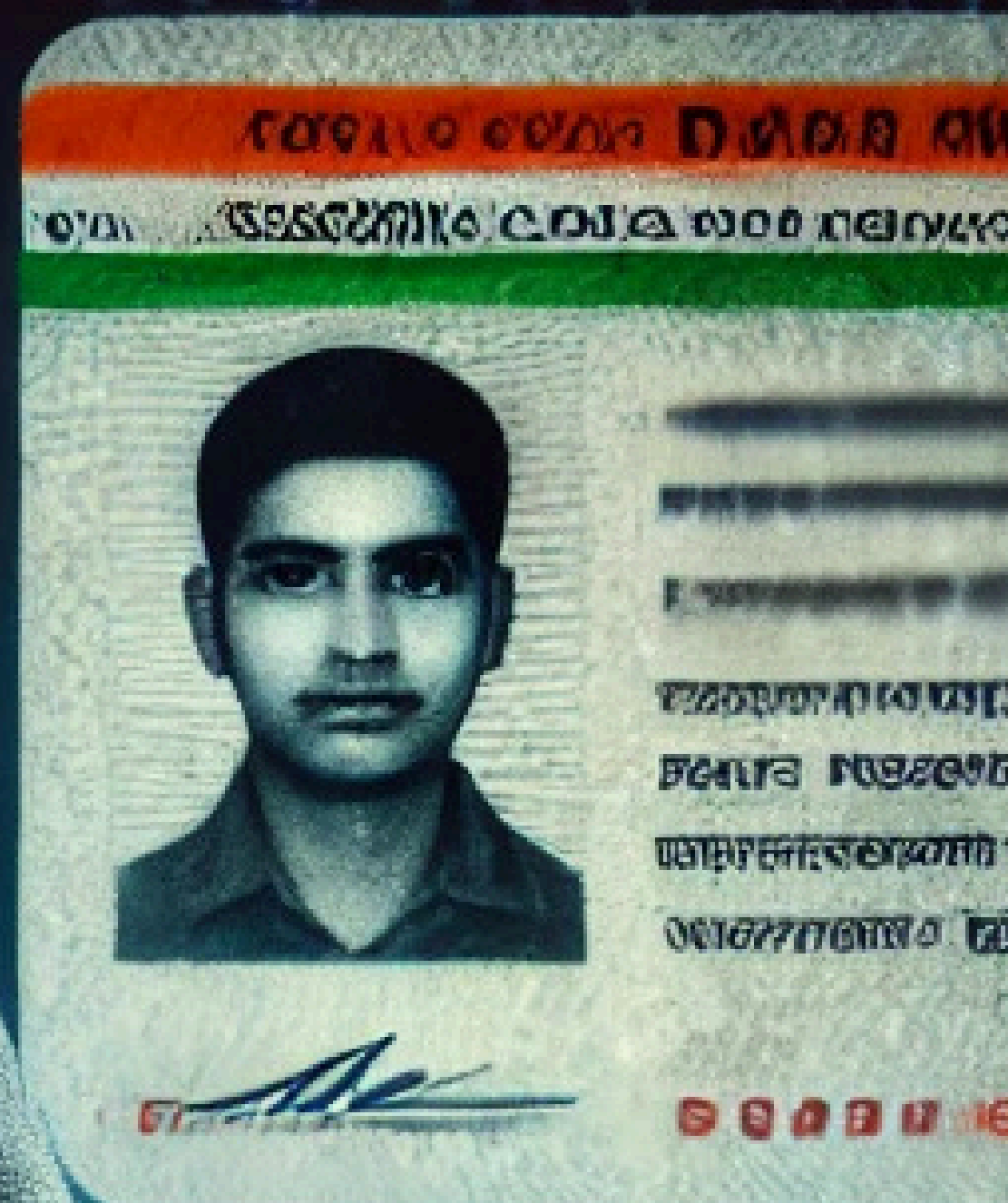




DATA SALES



DATA CARD



DARK WALK

PAN CARD

**Dark Web Sales of
Indian Citizens' Data**



Dark Web Sales of Indian Citizens' Data

Introduction

The rise of cybercrime has led to the alarming sale of Indian citizens' personal data on the dark web. Reports have surfaced indicating massive databases containing sensitive information such as Aadhaar numbers, PAN details, and banking credentials being readily available for purchase. This exposes individuals to significant risks of identity theft, financial fraud, and other cybercrimes. This report examines the scale of data leaks, the associated risks, and government measures to combat these threats.

Massive Databases Available for Sale

The dark web has become a hub for illegal transactions involving personal data. Investigations have revealed large-scale breaches where cybercriminals have gained access to databases containing:

1. **Aadhaar Numbers** – Unique identification numbers linked to biometric and demographic data.
2. **PAN (Permanent Account Number) Details** – Essential for tax filings and financial transactions.
3. **Banking Information** – Account numbers, IFSC codes, credit card details, and transaction history.
4. **Mobile Numbers and Email IDs** – Used for communication and two-factor authentication.
5. **Health and Insurance Records** – Sensitive medical history and insurance claims data.

These databases are often sold in bulk on dark web forums, where cybercriminals use them for various fraudulent activities.

Risks of Identity Theft and Fraud

The exposure of Aadhaar, PAN, and banking details on the dark web poses severe risks, including:

1. **Identity Theft** – Fraudsters can use stolen Aadhaar and PAN details to impersonate individuals for illegal activities.
2. **Financial Fraud** – Cybercriminals can access bank accounts, make unauthorized transactions, or apply for loans using stolen credentials.
3. **Phishing and Social Engineering Attacks** – Hackers use leaked personal data to craft convincing scams targeting individuals.
4. **SIM Swapping Attacks** – Criminals clone mobile SIM cards to intercept OTPs and hijack banking accounts.
5. **Credit Card Fraud** – Stolen credit card information is used for unauthorized purchases or sold to third parties.

These risks emphasize the urgent need for robust cybersecurity measures to protect citizens' data from falling into the wrong hands.

Government Initiatives to Combat Data Leaks

Recognizing the seriousness of data breaches, the Indian government has introduced several initiatives to mitigate cyber threats and strengthen data protection. Key measures include:

1. **Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023**
 - Introduces strict guidelines on data collection, storage, and processing.
 - Imposes heavy penalties on entities failing to safeguard user data.
2. **Cyber Swachhta Kendra**
 - A cybersecurity initiative by CERT-In (Indian Computer Emergency Response Team) to provide tools and services for detecting and removing malware.
3. **National Cyber Security Policy**
 - Aims to strengthen India's cybersecurity infrastructure and response mechanisms.
 - Encourages public-private partnerships to combat cyber threats.
4. **Crackdown on Dark Web Activities**
 - Government agencies, in collaboration with international cybercrime units, are tracking and dismantling illegal data marketplaces.
 - Arrests and legal action against cybercriminals involved in data breaches.
5. **Public Awareness and Digital Hygiene Initiatives**
 - Conducting awareness programs on safe internet practices, strong password usage, and recognizing phishing scams.
 - Encouraging the use of multi-factor authentication (MFA) for financial transactions.

Conclusion

The sale of Indian citizens' data on the dark web is a critical cybersecurity challenge with far-reaching consequences. From financial fraud to identity theft, the risks are immense. However, through stringent data protection laws, cybersecurity initiatives, and increased public awareness, the government is taking proactive steps to curb these threats. Individuals must also play a role by adopting secure online practices and staying vigilant against potential scams. A collaborative effort between authorities, organizations, and citizens is essential to safeguard personal data and prevent cybercriminals from exploiting sensitive information.